

MATT DEBUTTS

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Education

Stanford University Ph.D. in Political Communication; Advisor: Jennifer Pan <i>Ph.D. minor in Political Science</i> M.A. in Communication; Knight-Hennessy Scholar	Stanford, CA 2021-present 2019-2021
Peking University M.A. in China Studies; Yenching Academy	Beijing, China 2016-2018
Amherst College B.A. in Law, Jurisprudence and Social Thought <i>Distinctions: Phi Beta Kappa, Magna Cum Laude</i>	Amherst, MA 2010-2014

Publications

PEER-REVIEWED

- [1] **Matt DeButts**, Tongtong Zhang. Rising Engagement and Substantive Responsiveness: Thirteen Years of Online Petitioning in China (*forthcoming*, 2026). *China Quarterly*.
- [2] **Matt DeButts**, Jennifer Pan. Reporting After Removal: The Effects of Journalist Expulsion on Foreign News Coverage (2024). *Journal of Communication*.
- [3] Alexander Spangher, James Youn, **Matt DeButts**, Nanyun Peng, Emilio Ferrara, Jonathan May. Explaining Mixtures of Sources in News Articles (2024). *EMNLP Proceedings*.
- [4] **Matt DeButts**, Jennifer Pan. China's Internet Controls: What if Citizens Disengage? (2024). *Communication and the Public*.
- [5] Kate Starbird, Renee DiResta, **Matt DeButts**. Influence and Improvisation: Participatory Disinformation during the 2020 U.S. Election (2023). *Social Media+ Society*.

PAPERS UNDER REVIEW

- [1] **Matt DeButts**, Yingdan Lu. Intimacy with Limits: How Short-form Video Propaganda Embraces Platform Norms, but not for Leaders. (R&R minor revisions at *Journal of Communication*)

BOOK CHAPTER

- [1] Lu, Y. & **DeButts, M.** (2026). How to use computational methods and online experiments to study Chinese digital media. In Xu J., Guo S., and Zhang W. (Eds.), *The Sage Handbook on Chinese Digital Media and Communication*.

SELECTED WORKS IN PROGRESS

- [1] **Matt DeButts**, Jennifer Pan. Media Patronage: How Authoritarian Regimes Exploit Media Competition to Shape Global Information. (*Presented at APSA 2025*)
- [2] **Matt DeButts**, Tongtong Zhang. Rightful but Unrewarded: A Hierarchy of Legitimation in Everyday Authoritarian Governance. (*Presented at ICA 2025*)
- [3] **Matt DeButts**. "The Advantages of Overt Censorship: How Platform Blocking Enables China to Reshape the Global Information Ecosystem." (*Dissertation chapter*)
- [4] **Matt DeButts**, Alexander Spangher. "Liquid News and Government Gatekeeping."

POLICY

- [1] Renee DiResta, **Matt DeButts**. “‘Newsworthiness,’ Trump, and the Facebook Oversight Board.” (April 2021) *Columbia Journalism Review*. (https://www.cjr.org/the_new_gatekeepers/facebook-oversight-board-2.php)
- [2] **Matt DeButts**. “The Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs Twitter Data Set.” (April 2021). *U.S. China Perception Monitor*, Carter Center. (<https://uscnpm.org/2021/04/14/the-chinese-mfa-data-set-insights/>)
- [3] Jack Cable, **Matt DeButts**, Renee DiResta, Riana Pfefferkorn, Alex Stamos, David Thiel. “Clubhouse in China: Is the data safe?” (February 2021).
- [4] **Matt DeButts**, Maya Guzdar, Vanessa Molter. “Chinese Expat News Site Resists CCP Influence.” (September 2020).
- [5] Center for an Informed Public, Digital Forensic Research Lab, Graphika, & Stanford Internet Observatory (March 2021). *The Long Fuse: Misinformation and the 2020 Election*. Stanford Digital Repository: Election Integrity Partnership.

JOURNALISM

- [1] **Matt DeButts**, [The Hotel at the Epicenter of China’s Online Film Industry](#), *Los Angeles Times*. 2017
- [2] **Matt DeButts**, [Chinese Turn to Sex Education to Prevent Abuse](#), *Los Angeles Times*. 2017
- [3] **Matt DeButts**, [Ask the Chinese: Public Opinion and Trump](#), *Los Angeles Times*. 2017
- [4] **Matt DeButts**, [UCLA Basketball Players are “Doing Fine” in Hotel Detention](#), *Los Angeles Times*. 2017
- [5] **Matt DeButts**, [When China Reporters Can’t Report From China](#), *ChinaFile*. 2020
- [6] **Matt DeButts**, [The Other Hospital Workers on the Pandemic’s Front Lines](#), *Vox*. 2020
- [7] **Matt DeButts**, [Urgency for Pro-Democracy Hong Kong Expatriates in the Bay Area](#), *SFGate*. 2019.
- [8] **Matt DeButts**, [How a Popular Chinese App is Turning Clicks into Connections](#), *Sixth Tone*. 2019.
- [9] **Matt DeButts**, [How the ‘Home of Overseas Chinese’ is Memorializing Migrants](#), *Sixth Tone*. 2017
- [10] **Matt DeButts**, [China’s Students Are Sharing Their Secrets...In English](#), *Foreign Policy*. 2016.

CHINESE LANGUAGE

- [1] 硅谷多媒体: [为什么拜登的副总统人选一波三折而又如此重要](#): “Biden’s Choice of VP”
- [2] 2020 — 硅谷多媒体 《[硅谷三人行 1](#)》 — “Silicon Valley Chats” (video)
- [3] 2020 — 硅谷多媒体 《[硅谷三人行 2](#)》
- [4] 2019 — IUP 中文中心: 《[失忆的王国](#)》 — “The Kingdom of Forgotten Things.”

Presentations

Invited Talks & Workshops

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|--|----------|
| - Stanford HAI AI+Science: Accelerating Discovery (lightning talk) | May 2026 |
| - UC-Fudan Young Scholars | May 2026 |
| - University of Wisconsin (Journalism & Mass Communication) | Apr 2026 |
| - China Politics Research in Progress | Feb 2026 |
| - Virtual Workshop on Authoritarian Regimes | Jan 2026 |
| - Junior Law and Politics Online Seminar | Nov 2025 |

Annual Conferences

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| - American Political Science Association (APSA) | 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026 |
| - Comm Horizons | 2026 |
| - Midwestern Political Science Association (MPSA) | 2023, 2026 |
| - Western Political Science Association (WPSA) | 2026 |
| - Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC) | 2025, 2026 |
| - International Society for Computational Social Science (IC2S2) | 2025 |
| - International Communication Association (ICA) | 2023, 2024, 2025 |
| - International Journal of Press/Politics (IJPP) | 2023 |

Teaching

Guest Lecturer

Introduction to Word Embeddings, SICSS-Stanford, 2025

Political Self-Censorship, Stanford COMM 158/258: Censorship and Propaganda, 2025

Agenda-setting, Stanford COMM 108/208: Media Processes and Effects, 2024

Teaching Assistant

Comm 106/206: Communication Research Methods, Stanford, 2023

Comm 158/258: Censorship and Propaganda, Stanford, 2022, 2025

Service

Manuscript reviewer: *Journal of Quantitative Methods: Digital Media* (2026), *International Journal of Press/Politics* (2026), *New Media & Society* (2025), *Harvard Misinformation Review* (2024), *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications* (2024), *Information, Communication and Society* (2024), *The Communication Review* (2023)

Conference Discussant/Chair: APSA 2025

Departmental: Colloquium Speaker Series, Political Communication Division Representative

Experience

Stanford Internet Observatory.....	Graduate Research Assistant.....	2020-2023
Economist Intelligence Unit.....	Contributing Editor.....	2017-2019
Los Angeles Times.....	Special Correspondent.....	2017-2018
C4ADS.....	Summer Analyst (OSINT).....	2019
Trivium/China.....	Politics Researcher.....	2018
Princeton-in-Asia	Teaching Fellow, China Foreign Affairs University.....	2014-2015

Fellowships, Grants & Awards

2026	AEJMC Top Refereed Student Research Paper Session Award Winner
	National Science Foundation (NSF) ACCESS Pegasus Grant (\$5000)
2025	Stanford Data Science PhD Scholar (\$100,000)
	Stanford Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence (HAI) Graduate Fellow (\$5000)
	Human-Center Artificial Intelligence (HAI) Google Cloud Grant (\$4600)
	Milton Wolf Seminar on Media and Diplomacy Emerging Scholar
	Stanford Center on China's Economy & Institutions (SCCEI) Graduate Fellowship (\$100,000)
2024	Stanford Institute for Research in the Social Sciences Grant (IRiSS) (\$1,500)
	Human-Center Artificial Intelligence (HAI) Google Cloud Grant (\$4600)
2023	Stanford Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence (HAI) Graduate Fellow (\$3000)
	Stanford Center on China's Economy & Institutions (SCCEI) Research Grant (\$9500)
2022	Stanford PACS Small grant (\$1500)
	Human-Center Artificial Intelligence (HAI) Google Cloud Grant (\$2200)
2019	Knight-Hennessy Scholarship (3-year funded graduate fellowship at Stanford University)
2019	Overseas Press Club Fellow (\$4000 for overseas reporting)
2018	Blakemore-Freeman Graduate Fellowship (\$50000 for language study)

Skills and Languages

Programming: Python, R (Tidyverse)

Languages: Mandarin (fluent), Spanish (proficient)